


*Source: By September 2020, RSS had a live interactive new membership tracker on its website. Hovering the cursor over a state throws up the name of the latest person to have joined the RSS from that state that day, and the time of joining. The screengrab above is from 24 September 2020. It displays the name of the latest person who had joined RSS that day from Karnataka.* https://www.rss.org/

The roots of these social-media strategies can be traced back to 1999 when the RSS started its first 'cybershakha' on the occasion of its Hindi magazine *Panchjanya* going online. This was the pre-smartphone era, when the internet was mostly accessed through dial-up modems. The then RSS chief Rajju Bhaiyya delivered a brief 'Baudhik' (intellectual discourse) on the internet from Delhi, and then replied to emails from all over the world. In 1999, the Sangh announced three new departures for these cyber shakhas: attendees did not have to wear RSS uniforms, they could approach the RSS supremo directly and women could 'send messages to the RSS chief'. Never before had 'women been permitted access to the RSS